JOURNEY

Science

BIG IDEA

Students are often taught that faith and science belong in separate worlds. They don't: the more we discover through science, the more we see how awesome God is, and science lays a foundation for understanding our world instead of contradicting our faith.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. You don't need to be a science expert. Students are widely taught that faith and science don't belong together; the speaker's own teacher drew that line back in seventh grade.
2. As STEM studies and careers grow more popular, that split will only sharpen. Students need to see the two worlds connect: discovering more through science means discovering more of God.
3. Don't try to master all the science yourself. Instead, find the students who love science, math or technology and get them engaged now.
4. Make the storyteller the centerpiece this week: someone from your church who works in the sciences. Talk with them first; even Christian teachers can struggle to make the connection.
5. Beyond the provided questions, ask students what they're studying in school, even bring textbooks. Let them teach you while you help them see the biblical worldview behind it.
6. We often live in a two-story house: Jesus kept upstairs in the private sphere, school and work downstairs in public. The goal is to bring Jesus into the public space.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Where do I keep my faith upstairs, separate from my work or public life?
2. Who in our church could tell students how they see God in their scientific work?
3. What would help me lead a science unit with confidence, even without being an expert?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What are you studying in science or math right now, and how might it connect to what you believe about God?
2. Have you ever been told faith and science don't belong together? How did that land with you?
3. What's something about the natural world that makes you wonder who, or what, is behind it?
4. Where do you find it easiest, and hardest, to bring your faith into school or work?
5. What questions about science and faith would you most like this unit to answer?

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WEEK 9 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Talking about science

0:06 All right, so now we get to talk about science. We get to talk about design. We get to talk about DNA. We get to talk about — well, let's be honest — we get to talk about a lot of things that several of us probably don't have a ton of expertise in. We talk about truth and logic and even what our faith is, and for most of us youth leaders, that's in our wheelhouse. But when we get into things like science, it gets a little bit more tricky.

0:39 You don't have to be an expert in this space. But I want you to pay attention to a couple of things and remember a couple of things as you work through these next several weeks focusing on things like science. Our students are taught this: if you ask your students, if you go into the public school classroom and look inside what their textbooks say and what teachers are saying, there is this sort of separation between things of faith and things of science. We're told that these things don't belong together.

A seventh grade lesson

1:11 I remember even back when I was in seventh grade, many years ago, I was told something by my teacher. I looked up and saw this chart of a monkey suddenly becoming more and more, evolving into a man, and I remember looking at that and thinking, how can that be? I remember raising my hand and asking the question, saying this doesn't seem right. And I'll never forget what she said to me. It seemed to solve it for me. She said, "I get what you're saying, but that is religion and faith, and this is science." Even right there as a seventh grader, the dichotomy, the split, the two separate spheres of life were defined for me.

1:56 So for our students, that really is what's happening a lot. A lot of students are okay with that and they're comfortable with it, and that's fine. But the more we research, the more technologically advanced we become, the more STEM research and STEM-like subjects and careers become more popular and much more pursued by our students post-college, the more this separation is going to get defined. So it's crucially important that our students understand — and guess what? — these two things don't actually need to be separated. In fact, the more we discover through science, the more we actually are going to discover about God, and the more we discover how awesome he really is. Over these next couple of weeks, you're actually going to start to see that.

2:49 So don't feel like you have to know all the science. Don't run out to the library and get a bunch of science books and try to figure it all out. I've tried. Unless that's your thing — then knock yourself out. But for most of us, it's probably not a time thing we have, nor maybe even the ability. So don't worry about that. Focus on getting your students to see that these two worlds actually interconnect. I might even suggest that you find some of those students who are

really, really amped up about science and love it — whether it be math, whether it be even computer technology, anything in biochemistry, anything in the science world — and get them switched on here and now. This is a great way to get some of those students engaged.

Find a storyteller

3:37 So for this first week, I think one of the crucial parts of your gathering is going to be your storyteller. Really focus in on somebody who can connect science and faith. I would suggest you either find a university professor, find somebody in the science field, or find somebody who actually does biology or chemistry or some field in the sciences and is in your church congregation — somebody who can stand up and say to the students, "Here is how I connect these two things together. This is how I can see God when I'm looking through a telescope or a microscope. This is how I can see God in the field of math," or whatever it might be.

4:21 It's hard. And trust me, you're going to need to sit down and probably have a conversation with the person you'd like to do this, and make sure that they can comfortably make that connection. I've even talked to Christian educators who are math teachers and English teachers and science teachers who, even as their profession, have a really, really difficult time sometimes making those connections. I've done seminars with some teachers, helping them — especially math teachers, for some reason — to make that connection, so they can see their subject matter through a biblical lens.

4:54 So make sure you sit down with those people and help them see it if they don't already see it, but make sure that they can deliver that message to your students, because this is a crucial moment. If your students can see that from somebody else in your congregation who actually does some of the jobs that they might be pursuing down the road, that's a huge, huge win for you as you move forward in this study.

Talk about school subjects

5:21 So in addition to the questions that we've provided for you, it would be a really, really good idea for you to talk specifically with your students about some of the school subjects and some of the things that they're actually learning in school. So whatever they happen to be learning at this particular time in their curriculum, have them talk about that. You might even have them bring in their textbooks.

5:44 Have them talk about what the things are that they're learning, so they can specifically tie in the subject matter that they're dealing with in school and their Christian worldview, and so that you can help them make those connections. Again, you don't have to know everything about that particular subject. You guys can work through that together. In fact, it's a great opportunity to have your students teach you about what they're learning. It's going to help them learn it, and then you can help them see the biblical worldview behind it.

Private and public spheres

6:13 So what we often forget is that in the school world — and in a lot of our professional worlds too — we have this thing called two different aspects of our world. We have what's called the private sphere, and we have what's called the public sphere. This is important to get.

6:33 If you think of this as a house, this is your upstairs, where your bedrooms are, and what you think and what you do up in your bedrooms is your private business, right? Not many other people are going to be up there. But when you have people over for company or whatever, you have your public spheres. This would be your kitchen, your living room, those kinds of things. These are two different spheres of life, and the things that you do here are not the same as what you do here.

7:00 Oftentimes, the way we think is the exact same thing. So what our students — and sometimes we ourselves — will do is put our school or our jobs in our public life, and we'll talk about some things specifically there. But then we'll put our Jesus life up in our private sphere, and we separate these two things, and we don't want them to connect, and we learn to live that way. Just as I was taught in seventh grade, this is exactly what my teacher was telling me to do: separate these two things, live in a two-story home, and leave it that way.

The bottom line

7:37 What we want to do is get rid of this and put Jesus down in our public space. So here's the bottom line. Science doesn't actually contradict our faith. Instead, it lays a crucial foundation for understanding our world.